



READING RISK | FOR ORGANIZERS

COMPOUND RISK

READ THE WHOLE PICTURE

COMPOUND RISK FOR ORGANIZERS

One thing may be manageable. Several together can change the decision. Read each factor. Then read what they mean together.

WHO THIS IS FOR

For race directors, safety officers and event teams. Organizers already make these judgments. Reading Risk gives the whole team a shared vocabulary for connecting information across the operation.

READ THIS GUIDE ONLINE

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources/compound-risk-for-organizers>

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INTRODUCTION

COMPOUND RISK FOR ORGANIZERS

Compound Risk is what happens when several factors interact and create a different situation than any one factor would create on its own.

One concern may be manageable. Another may also be manageable. Together they can change the margin for error, how effective an existing control is, how difficult a response becomes, and whether the operating plan still makes sense.

The second factor can change the meaning of the first.

WHY IT MATTERS

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An operation can change without any one part clearly failing.

Wind rising. A field spreading. A safety craft drifting off station. Visibility declining. A start running late. None of these automatically means stop. But each one changes the context for the others.

Compound Risk asks the organizer to connect information across the whole operation rather than waiting for one variable to cross a single threshold. Good decisions rarely begin with confidence. They begin with curiosity and paying attention.

HOW IT WORKS

ONE FACTOR CAN CHANGE ANOTHER.

These are illustrations of interaction, not equations. Each shows an accepted condition changing meaning when a second one appears.

VISIBILITY

- Reduced visibility: alone may be manageable.
- A field spreading wider than planned: and visibility matters more.
- Safety assets already near the edge of their coverage: and the same visibility may now require a different plan.

EXPOSURE

- Water temperature within your stated limit: may be routine.
- A long-distance event: and total exposure changes.
- Falling air temperature and wind at the exit: and the same measurement means something different operationally.

TIMING

- A delayed start: may be an inconvenience.
- Conditions building through the morning: and the swim window shifts.
- Slower finishers still on course: and the plan now covers a period nobody planned for.

THE METHOD

READ THE WHOLE PICTURE IN THREE MOVES.

The same three moves work in planning, at the start line, and while the event is running. Only the information changes.

1 READ EACH FACTOR

WHAT IS HAPPENING?

Use CHECK, ABLE, FLOW and CARE to gather the individual pieces: conditions, participant population, change during the event, and the exit and recovery.

2 CONNECT THE FACTORS

DOES ONE OF THESE MAKE ANOTHER HARDER TO MANAGE?

Ask what each factor does to detection, response time, coverage and the effectiveness of the controls you already have in place.

- Does poor visibility make thin coverage more important?
- Does a spreading field make current more consequential?
- Does cold exposure make a distant recovery area matter more?

3 REASSESS THE DECISION

KNOWING ALL OF THIS TOGETHER, DOES THE ORIGINAL PLAN STILL FIT?

Not whether each factor sits inside its own limit, but whether the operation as planned still matches the event you are running.

THE PRINCIPLE

ACCEPTABLE IS PROVISIONAL.

A factor judged acceptable earlier does not stay automatically acceptable when something else changes. When a second factor becomes borderline, evaluate the combination rather than adding another isolated control on top of the last one.

NOTE

There is no fixed count. When concerns interact, reduce your margin, or make existing controls less effective, step back and reassess the whole operating picture at system level.

SCENARIOS

FIELD SPREAD, VISIBILITY AND COVERAGE

- Participants are spreading wider than expected.
- Visibility is declining.
- Safety assets are already working near the edge of their planned coverage.

None of those facts should be assessed only in isolation. Together they describe your ability to find and reach someone.

ASK

What does this combination do to our ability to find and reach someone who needs help?

CONDITIONS, DURATION AND SCALE

- A condition sits within an established limit.
- The event is long, and the field is large.
- Wind, current, air temperature and support all vary through the swim window.

A limit tells you about one variable. It does not tell you what that variable means for this distance, this field and today's conditions. Fixed maximum water-temperature policies that do not account for event distance are a familiar example of a control that reads one number and misses the operating picture.

ASK

What important context is missing if we look only at the threshold?

MULTIPLE REPORTS BECOME ONE PICTURE

- One safety craft reports increasing current.
- Another reports swimmers spreading.
- A third reports visibility becoming more difficult.

Individually, none may trigger a dramatic response. Together they may be describing the same changing operation. Good systems make sure separate observations reach someone with the authority to act on them.

ASK

Who is responsible for connecting separate observations into one operating picture?

ACROSS THE STAGES

- check (Read the Conditions): What environmental factors are present?
- able (Read Readiness): What does the swimmer bring into those conditions?
- flow (Read Change): What has changed since the swim began?
- care (Read Recovery): What is the swimmer carrying out of the water?

THE HABIT

GOOD JUDGMENT STARTS WITH NOTICING.

Reading Risk is not about predicting everything that might happen. It is about noticing what matters, connecting information, and building a system capable of acting on it.

- Observation over assumption: Run the event in front of you, not the event your plan describes.
- Curiosity over certainty: A report does not need to be complete before someone follows up on it.
- Connection over checklists: Separate observations become an operating picture only when someone puts them together.
- Adaptation over ego: A changed plan is often evidence that the system is working, and it is easier to explain than an unchanged one.

WRITE IT DOWN

RECORD THAT THE FACTORS WERE CONSIDERED TOGETHER.

When multiple factors shape a decision, the record should show the combination, not a list of separate boxes.

- Date, event, and time of the decision
- The factors considered together
- How they interacted
- The decision made
- Who authorized it
- Why: what the combination changed
- Who was informed Written at the time, this is both an operational handover and the clearest account of your reasoning afterwards.

COMPOUND RISK

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Compound Risk is the lens across CHECK, ABLE, FLOW and CARE. It asks what all four are telling you together.

- The field is spreading wider than planned.
- Visibility is declining.
- Coverage is at the edge of its plan.
- Conditions are building through the swim window.

Each sits inside its own limit. Together they describe an operation with less ability to find and reach someone than the plan assumed.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

CONNECT THE INFORMATION BEFORE MOMENTUM MAKES THE DECISION.

This is an operating judgment about the combination. Full re-evaluation does not automatically mean cancel.

PROCEED / PLAN HOLDS

The combined operating picture remains well within the plan.

MODIFY / CHANGE A CONTROL

The combination requires changes to course, coverage, timing, staffing, briefing or another operational control.

FULL RE-EVALUATION / A SYSTEM-LEVEL DECISION

Multiple concerns are interacting and the operation needs a fresh decision. Outcomes may include changing safety deployment, modifying the course, delaying, shortening, stopping new entries, stopping the swim, or activating the EAP if an emergency exists.

OVERRIDE

The decision belongs to a named person with the authority to make it, and it should be made before schedule pressure makes it for you.

QUICK CHECK

In your last event, who was responsible for combining reports from different sources into one operating picture, and did everyone know that?

WHERE THIS LEADS NEXT

KEEP GOING

PRIMARY

EXPLORE SAFE ORGANIZER FOUNDATIONS

Event-level decision making and risk management, built on CHECK, ABLE, FLOW and CARE.

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/courses/safe-organizer>

RELATED

EXPLORE ALL READING RISK GUIDES

Fifteen guides for swimmers, coaches and organizers.

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources>

EXPLORE

RETURN TO CHECK FOR ORGANIZERS

Reading the conditions before the field enters the water.

<https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources/check-framework-for-event-organizers>

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

REFERENCES

Tipton and Bradford, cold and warm water immersion: a review of the physiological responses relevant to open water swimming

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4052348/>

Canonical guide: <https://www.openwaterswimming.com/learn/resources/compound-risk-for-organizers>

World Open Water Swimming Association, WOWSA Learn.